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Heritage across Landscapes, Technologies, Traditions, and Ecological Continuity

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Technical University of Applied Sciences Wurzburg-Schweinfurt (THWS)

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KALAGRIHA

Reimagining Performing Arts Infrastructure in Belagavi

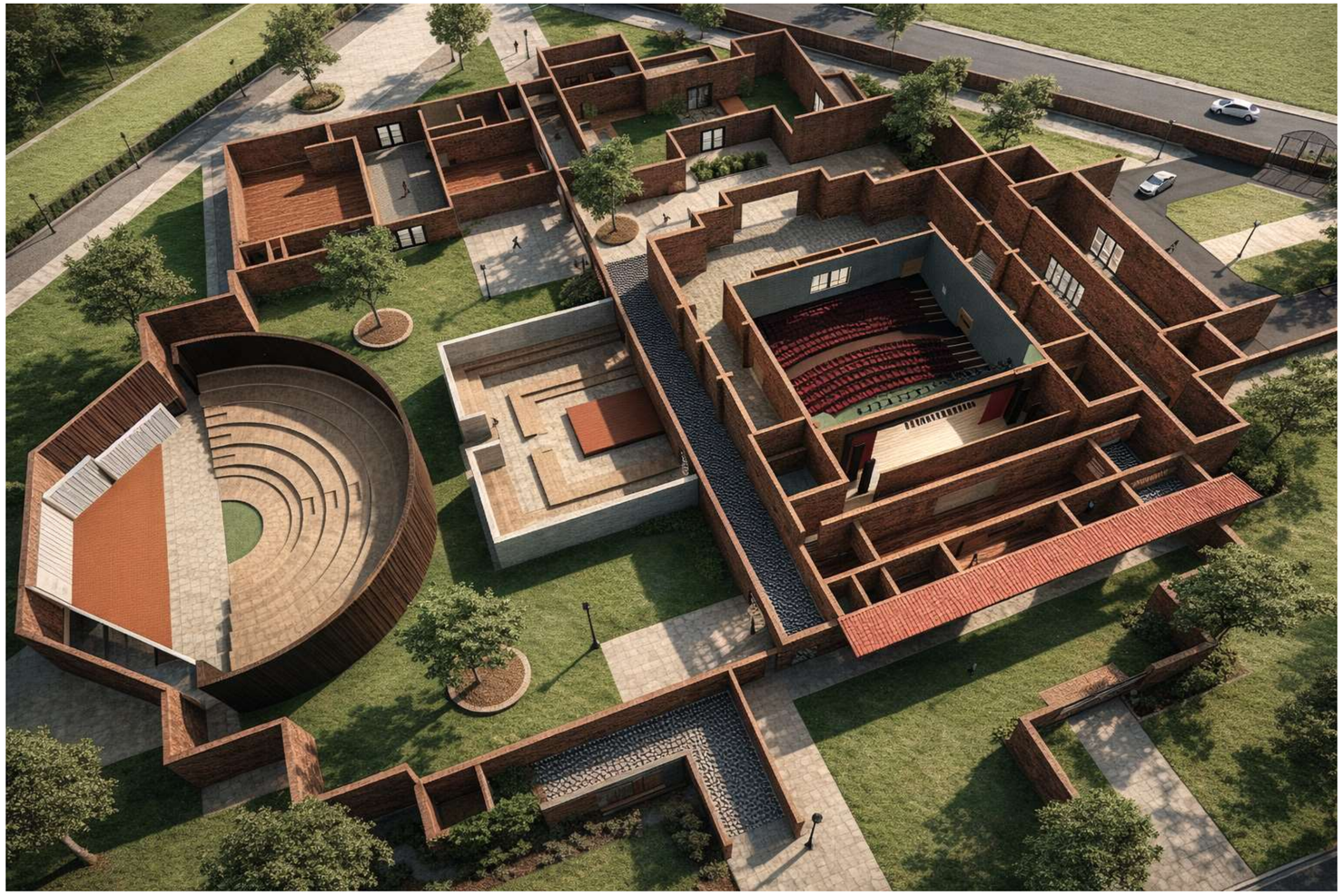
Conference ID: TEM 261035

Name of the Presenter: Tejas Jadhav

Introduction and Background

Brief Introduction

- Belagavi is a culturally significant Kannada–Marathi border city with a rich legacy of theatre, music, folk arts, and performing traditions.
- The city's artistic ecosystem evolved through bilingual theatre movements, folk performances, musical drama, and experimental stage practices.
- Performing arts in Belagavi are gradually declining due to ageing infrastructure, rising venue costs, artist migration, and changing audience preferences.
- Existing cultural facilities lack affordability, accessibility, technical support, and integrated spaces for contemporary theatre, film-making, training, and collaboration.
- This research investigates how architecture can help revive the city's performing arts ecosystem through the proposal of Kalagriha, an inclusive, affordable, and sustainable arts centre.



Aims and Objectives

Aims

- Rebuild Belagavi's performing arts ecosystem and reconnect youth to live arts.
- Promote Kannada–Marathi cultural unity through inclusive programming.
- Integrate theatre, film-making, and digital arts under one multidisciplinary hub.
- Strengthen the creative economy through training, festivals, and tourism.

Objectives

- Create professional-grade auditoriums, rehearsal rooms, and film screening studios.
- Establish structured acting and film training with university collaboration.
- Host bilingual cultural events to foster shared artistic identity.
- Ensure affordability through subsidised rentals and student-led access.
- Build national/international partnerships for mentoring and residencies.



Future Scope and Limitations

Future scope

- Similar studies can be undertaken in other mid-sized Indian cities.
- Future research can assess the long-term social, cultural, and economic impacts of arts centres.
- Comparative studies on governance, funding models, and community participation can strengthen cultural infrastructure planning.
- Emerging digital technologies, hybrid performance spaces, and changing audience behaviour can inform future performing arts facilities.

Limitations

- Focused specifically on Belagavi's cultural and infrastructural context.
- Survey findings represent a limited stakeholder sample.
- Kalagriha remains an academic proposal without real-world operational evaluation.
- Detailed financial feasibility and funding studies are beyond the study scope.
- Government involvement, institutional partnerships, land allocation, and policy integration require further investigation for implementation.

Research Aim, Objectives & Questions

Research Aim

To study how architecture can revitalise Belagavi’s declining performing arts ecosystem by designing an integrated, sustainable arts centre that fosters cultural exchange, artistic development, community participation, and affordable access to creative infrastructure.

Research Objectives

- Document Belagavi's theatre heritage and cultural identity.
- Highlight the decline of performing arts and its impact on the city's cultural ecosystem.
- Assess the needs of artists, students, and cultural stakeholders.
- Develop an affordable, sustainable, and integrated arts centre.
- Revive cultural participation through inclusive architectural design.

Research Questions

- What factors have contributed to the decline of Belagavi's performing arts ecosystem?
- What is the need for an integrated performing arts and cultural centre in Belagavi's contemporary context?
- How can architecture address the cultural and infrastructural needs of artists, students, and creative communities?

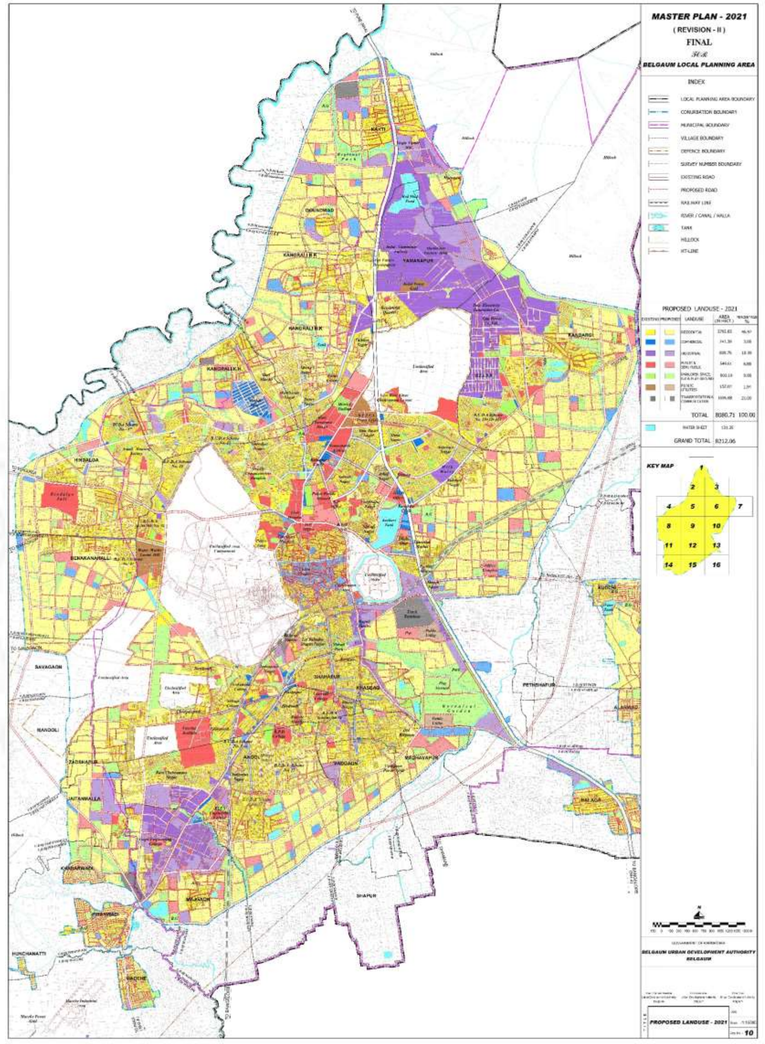
Literature Review

Belagavi and Theatre

- Belagavi is a unique Kannada–Marathi border city where language, identity, and performance traditions intersect.
- Its theatre culture evolved through cross-cultural influences, blending Marathi musical theatre, Kannada folk forms, and modern drama.
- Theatre movements in Karnataka and Maharashtra significantly shaped Belagavi's bilingual performing arts.
- Theatre has long served as a platform for cultural exchange, connecting diverse linguistic communities.
- Despite its rich artistic heritage, Belagavi lacks an integrated cultural infrastructure for contemporary theatre, filmmaking, training, and community engagement.

Socio-political and Cultural dynamics

- Belagavi's bilingual Kannada–Marathi identity plays a significant role in shaping theatre traditions, audience preferences, and artistic expression.
- Community, religious, and social structures continue to influence cultural participation, representation, and the development of local performing arts practices.
- Economic, institutional, and funding constraints limit opportunities for artists, theatre groups, and emerging creative initiatives.
- Many existing cultural venues are expensive, outdated, and lack flexible facilities, making them less accessible to students and emerging artists.
- Creative city and cultural infrastructure theories emphasise the importance of affordable, inclusive, and community-oriented spaces in supporting cultural sustainability and artistic growth.



Conceptual Framework

Research Gap table

Research Gap	Missing Aspect	Kalagriha Response
Theatre history poorly documented	Lack of cultural archives	Documentation & resource centre
No spatial analysis of cultural venues	Infrastructure-performance relationship ignored	Purpose-built arts campus
Limited focus on youth theatre	Student needs underrepresented	Training & rehearsal spaces
Lack of digital adaptation studies	Few hybrid cultural models	Film-making & digital labs
Economic barriers for artists	High rentals and poor access	Affordable and subsidised venues

Creative City Framework

Scholar / Theory	Key Idea	Relevance to Kalagriha
Landry (2000)	Accessible and inclusive cultural spaces strengthen cities.	Supports a community-oriented arts centre.
Florida (2002)	Creative environments attract and retain talent.	Encourages youth engagement and artistic growth.
Evans (2001)	Arts infrastructure strengthens identity and urban development.	Justifies investment in cultural infrastructure.
Lefebvre (1991)	Space shapes social and cultural relationships.	Informs people-centric spatial design.
Literature Synthesis	Cultural institutions support learning, interaction, and creativity.	Forms the basis of Kalagriha's integrated approach.

Research Methodology

- **Pre-Thesis Exploration**: Identified the need for a performing arts centre in Belagavi.
- **Architectural Thesis Development**: Developed Kalagriha as a comprehensive design proposal.
- **Literature & Historical Research**: Studied Belagavi's theatre heritage, cultural identity, and existing conditions.
- **Stakeholder Surveys**: Collected responses from artists, students, and the general public.
- **Field Studies**: Assessed existing cultural venues, infrastructure gaps, and operational challenges.
- **Case Study Analysis**: Examined national and international performing arts institutions.
- **Data Synthesis**: Interpreted findings to establish need, relevance, and design strategies.
- **Research Outcome**: Proposed Kalagriha as an affordable, sustainable, and community-oriented arts centre.
- **Future Direction**: Explore implementation, governance, and real-world execution of the project.

Case Studies and Lessons

- Indian examples like Rangashankara and Ninasam show how accessible infrastructure and training sustain local theatre cultures, while global models such as the Young Vic and Market Theatre highlight innovation, adaptive reuse, and public participation. These case studies collectively inform strategic directions for developing *KALAGRIHA* into an inclusive, future-ready arts centre for Belagavi.

Case Study	Type	Key Strength	Design Lesson for Kalagriha
Rangashankara, Bengaluru	Urban Theatre Model	Affordable rentals and regular programming	Adopt a low-rent, high-use cultural model
Ninasam, Heggodu	Community Theatre Model	Grassroots participation and cultural rootedness	Build a community-driven and inclusive arts ecosystem
Young Vic, London	Youth-Centred Theatre Model	Flexible spaces and strong audience outreach	Create adaptable venues and youth-focused programming
Market Theatre, Johannesburg	Socially Engaged Theatre Model	Community activism and cultural representation	Use theatre as a platform for identity and social dialogue



RANGASHANKARA


NINASM


YOUNG VIC THEATRE


MARKET THEATRE

Key Findings and Discussion

Findings: Decline of Existing Theatres in Belagavi

- Lokmanya Rangamandir and Gogte Rangamandir are historically significant landmarks that shaped Belagavi's Kannada–Marathi theatre culture.
- Ageing infrastructure, outdated technology, and inadequate maintenance have reduced their usability for contemporary performances.
- High rental costs and limited accessibility discourage students, amateur groups, and emerging artists from using these venues.
- Digital entertainment, artist migration, and fragmented institutional support have further weakened regular theatre activities and audience engagement.
- Theatres require conservation, modernisation, and affordable public access to restore their role within Belagavi's performing arts ecosystem.





Discussion:

- The study concludes that revitalising these historic theatres alongside the proposed Kalagriha will create a complementary cultural network—preserving heritage while providing future-ready infrastructure for artists and the community.

Key Findings and Discussion

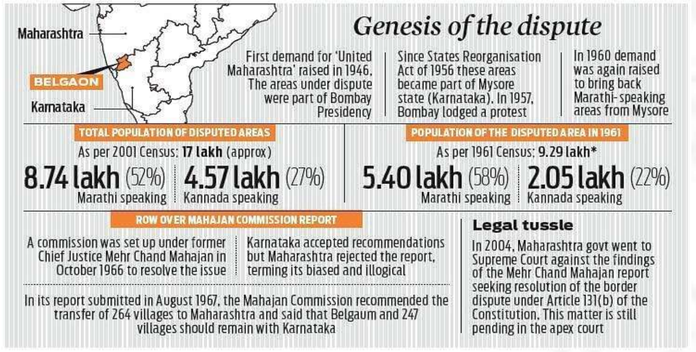
Findings: Belagavi's Linguistic Context and Cultural Identity

- Belagavi's location at the Karnataka–Maharashtra border has created a unique bilingual cultural identity.
- The linguistic dispute has influenced theatre institutions, audience preferences, and cultural programming over several decades.
- Despite political differences, theatre has remained a common platform connecting Kannada and Marathi artistic communities.
- The city's shared cultural heritage presents an opportunity to strengthen dialogue through neutral public cultural spaces.
- Kalagriha is proposed as a politically neutral and inclusive arts centre, promoting artistic collaboration beyond linguistic boundaries.

Discussion:

- Architecture can function as a cultural bridge by creating spaces that celebrate both Kannada and Marathi traditions equally.
- Shared libraries, bilingual archives, exhibitions, flexible performance venues, and community spaces encourage cultural exchange while remaining free from political influence.
- The research identifies cultural infrastructure as a tool for unity, preservation, and long-term artistic sustainability in Belagavi.





Genesis of the Dispute Source: The Times of India

Indicator	Belagavi District (2011 Census)
Total Population	**47.80 lakh**
Kannada Speakers	68.4%
Marathi Speakers	18.7%
Urdu Speakers	9.8%
Other Languages	3.1%



The Belagavi Condrum: timesofindia.com

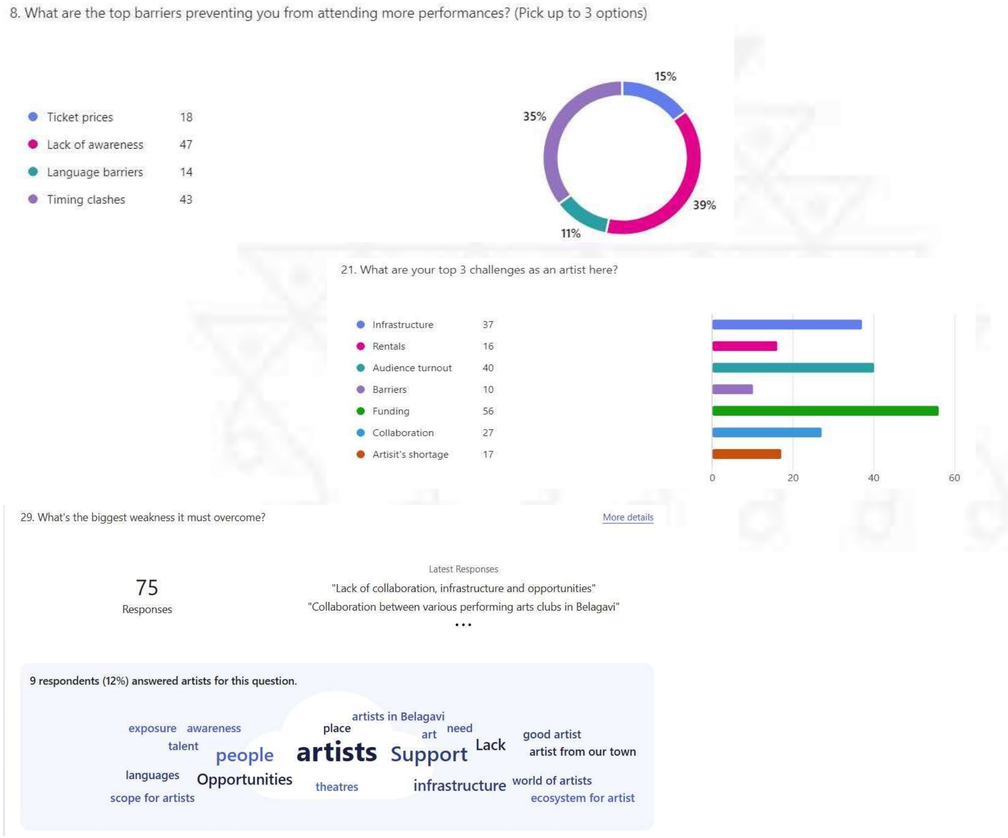
Key Findings and Discussion

Stakeholder Survey Analysis & Design Implications

Survey Link: https://forms.office.com/r/HdUWehyWMX

Survey Analysis: KALAGRIHA - Arts Centre for Thespians & Filmmakers at Belagavi – Results

Stakeholder	Key Findings	Architectural Response in Kalagriha
Students & General Public (44.1%)	Low participation due to outdated venues, poor accessibility, and limited cultural events.	Affordable multipurpose theatre, open-air amphitheatre, regular public programming.
Artists (51.7%)	High rental costs, inadequate technical infrastructure, and limited collaborative spaces.	Subsidised rental model, black-box theatre, proscenium theatre, shared creative spaces.
Cultural Leaders (4.2%)	Need for bilingual programming, community engagement, and sustainable management.	Flexible Kannada–Marathi venues, cultural commons, inclusive programming, community-oriented operation.
Overall Survey Outcome (143 Respondents)	Common concerns centred on affordability, accessibility, infrastructure gaps, and declining youth engagement.	Kalagriha integrates affordable, flexible, sustainable, and community-driven performing arts infrastructure.



Key Findings and Discussion

Relevance and Implications

The research establishes a clear need for Kalagriha as an affordable, inclusive, and sustainable arts centre that addresses Belagavi's cultural, social, architectural, and economic challenges through a single integrated intervention.

Major Finding	Implication
Declining youth engagement in performing arts due to digital entertainment and outdated venues.	Youth-oriented, technology-enabled creative spaces are required.
Migration of artists caused by limited opportunities and inadequate infrastructure.	Affordable, year-round artistic facilities can help retain talent.
Kannada–Marathi cultural divide limits collaboration and shared programming.	Inclusive bilingual spaces can strengthen cultural unity.
Existing cultural infrastructure is expensive, outdated, and lacks flexibility.	Modern, affordable, and adaptable performance spaces are essential.
Weak institutional coordination reduces the effectiveness of cultural initiatives.	A centralised arts hub can improve collaboration and governance.
Limited cultural economy and digital presence restrict long-term sustainability.	Integrated digital infrastructure and cultural tourism can support economic growth.

Heritage Contribution

Contribution to Heritage Conservation

- Preserves Belagavi's Kannada–Marathi performing arts heritage by providing dedicated spaces for theatre, music, and film-making.
- Promotes linguistic coexistence through bilingual programming, shared cultural spaces, and equal representation of Kannada and Marathi traditions.
- Revitalises historic theatres such as Lokmanya Rangamandir and Gogte Rangamandir by complementing their role within a larger cultural network.
- Safeguards intangible cultural heritage by encouraging traditional theatre forms, folk arts, storytelling, and regional performance practices.
- Documents and archives Belagavi's artistic legacy through digital repositories, libraries, and exhibition spaces for future generations.
- Encourages community participation and youth engagement, ensuring the continuity and transmission of artistic knowledge across generations.
- Strengthens cultural identity through sustainable architecture, creating an inclusive and accessible cultural institution that preserves heritage while supporting contemporary creative practices.

Conclusions to the Research

- Kalagriha establishes the need for an integrated performing arts centre that supports theatre, film-making, education, and community engagement in Belagavi.
- The project celebrates Belagavi's bilingual Kannada–Marathi identity through inclusive, culturally neutral, and people-oriented architectural spaces.
- Affordable, flexible, and sustainable infrastructure ensures greater accessibility for students, emerging artists, and grassroots theatre groups.
- A collaborative governance model involving government, educational institutions, cultural organisations, and artists promotes long-term operational sustainability.
- The proposal complements the revival of existing heritage theatres, preserving Belagavi's cultural legacy while strengthening its future creative ecosystem.
- Architecture is demonstrated as a catalyst for cultural revival, fostering artistic expression, social interaction, and community participation.
- The research highlights a practical model for conserving both tangible and intangible cultural heritage through contemporary architectural intervention.
- Kalagriha offers a replicable framework for mid-sized Indian cities, demonstrating how cultural infrastructure can strengthen identity, heritage conservation, creative economies, and long-term urban development.

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Acknowledgement and Q&A

This research is more than an academic project—it is where my two greatest passions, Architecture and Performing Arts, come together. Theatre has shaped who I am, while architecture has taught me to observe, question, and transform ideas into meaningful spaces. Kalagriha is the result of this shared journey.

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I also extend my heartfelt thanks to my mentors, teachers, colleagues, artists, friends, and family for their continuous support, encouragement, and belief in me throughout this journey.

I hope this work contributes, in some small way, to the cultural future of Belagavi and one day comes alive—not only on paper, but as a living space for artists and the community.

Thank You.

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Q&A